was the only power that could compete with China demographically, economically, politically, and culturally over the long term. China's rise, America's search for partners against the Chinese behemoth, and India's growing worry about the relentlessly increasing power gap with its northern neighbour would cause the entente between India and China to erode.

Rivalry, 1999–2008

The terrorist strikes on the twin towers of the World Trade Center in New York on 11 September 2001 have come to define our understanding of the international politics of the ensuing decade. The period stands out for the US's 'global war on terrorism', the support it received in varying degrees from India, China, and Russia, and the worries of the four powers about Islamist terrorism. In fact, though, fissures were growing, principally between the US and China. Delhi sided increasingly with Washington by the end of this period, and Beijing was increasingly alienated from Washington and more in sympathy with Moscow. From their entente, India and China were drifting into international rivalry.

Growing China–US conflict

China–US relations were mixed but increasingly tended towards conflict. Two events typified the widening gulf. In May 1999, the US Air Force mistakenly bombed the Chinese embassy in Belgrade during its campaign against the Federal Republic of Yugoslavia under Slobodan Milosevic. China accused the US of a deliberate attack, and street protests including attacks on American diplomatic missions on the mainland followed. Washington apologized several times for the attack and paid compensation for the death of three Chinese journalists as also damage to the embassy. Then, in April 2001, a US signals-intelligence aircraft hit a Chinese fighter in mid-air, leading to the death of a Chinese airman. The damaged US aircraft landed on China's Hainan island. Washington later issued letters of